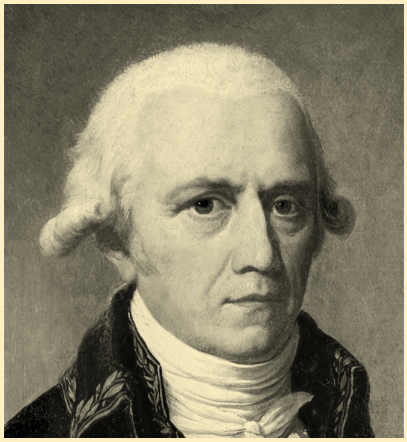
## Jean-Baptiste Lamarck



Born in 1744, Jean-Baptiste Lamarck attended a Jesuit college before joining the French army. Forced by an injury to resign, he studied medicine and then pursued his passion for plants, working at the Jardin du Roi (Royal Garden) in Paris. Supported by the Comte de Buffon, Lamarck was elected to the Academy of Sciences in 1779. When the Jardin's main building became the new National Museum of Natural History during the French Revolution (1789–99), Lamarck was placed in charge of the study of insects, worms, and microscopic organisms. He coined the biological term "invertebrate" and often used the relatively simpler forms of such species to illustrate his "ladder" of evolutionary progress. However, Lamarck's work was controversial and he died in poverty in 1829.

### Key works

**1802** *Research on the Organization of Living Bodies*

**1809** *Zoological Philosophy*

**1815–22** *Natural History of Invertebrate Animals*

**See also:** Extinction and change • Uniformitarianism • Evolution by natural selection • The rules of heredity